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Doing well in day job, Bonta should stay on

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Attorney General Rob Bonta, like many California Democrats of a certain level, looks at the field of candidates running to be governor and thinks: I could take that crew.

One word of advice as he ponders a run: Don't.

Instead, do something that few other politicians consider when presented with an opportunity to run for higher office: Stick with your day job that you're doing well.

I'd still bet the car that he runs for governor. It's what politicians do. They climb and they run. Rinse and repeat. It's the same way everyone tries to ascend the ladder at work -- except elected officials do it publicly and while being paid by us.

Bonta, the state's attorney general since Gov. Gavin Newsom appointed him in 2021, is doing a solid job at fulfilling the promise he made to Californians two days after Donald Trump was reelected in November 2024: "You can be sure that as California Attorney General, if Trump attacks your rights: I'll be there. If Trump comes after your freedoms: I'll be there."

As the Chronicle recently detailed, Bonta has sued the Trump administration 52 times in the first year of Trump 2.0. The courts have ruled in California's favor in about 80% of those cases, Bonta said, or the administration has backed down and agreed to settle. Bonta said the victories add up to $168 billion in savings for the state.

In suits that Bonta has led or joined, federal judges have blocked the Trump administration's freeze on virtually all domestic federal funding and mass layoffs in agencies such as the U.S. Department of Education and the AmeriCorps volunteer program. Federal courts have stopped Trump's deployment of California National Guard troops on the streets of Los Angeles, although they have allowed the president to take control of the Guard in California and other states. In a court filing last week, Trump agreed to return control of California's National Guard to the state. Courts have also prohibited him from requiring states such as California to join his immigration crackdown in order to keep billions of dollars in federal funding for highways and airports, aid to crime victims, and security against potential terrorist attacks.

Bonta hasn't been Perry Masoning all of these cases by himself. The California Department of Justice employs 1,100 attorneys and 3,700 non-attorney staffers. It's a team effort, but Bonta sets the tone.

He's also embraced another, newer aspect of his job: enforcing laws designed to make it easier to build housing in California, one of the state's biggest challenges. For decades, California municipalities have tried to weasel out of creating more housing -- particularly of the affordable kind -- and faced few consequences. That NIMBYism has led to a scarcity of housing, which drives up the price for all of us. Bonta has created a housing strike team and called out municipalities for trying to dodge housing mandates.

Part of his effectiveness is that since he became AG, Bonta has referred to his office (and himself) as "the people's attorney."

He looks at his job as protecting the little person -- or as Bonta described it to me shortly after getting the gig, in his rapid patter, "our most vulnerable, voiceless, hurt, harmed, abused, mistreated, cast aside, forgotten."

That framing is a far cry from how Kamala Harris used to refer to herself as California's "top cop" when she was the AG.

It's not a surprise or a sudden left turn. Bonta came to the job as a progressive legislator and the child of activists. His father marched in Selma, Ala., and organized for voting rights and civil rights in the 1960s. Bonta was born in 1972 in the Philippines, where his parents were doing Christian missionary work.

They returned to the U.S., and the family of five moved to a trailer in La Paz, in the Tehachapi Mountains near Bakersfield, close to the headquarters of the United Farm Workers. Much of Bonta'sperspective was shaped by the work his parents did there to organize Latino and Filipino farmworkers. They were close to Cesar Chavez, Dolores Huerta and Philip Vera Cruz, a Filipino American leader in the movement.

Whatever Bonta wants to call himself, he's doing the job pretty well so far -- at least in taking on Washington. So why move on? Because the opportunity has presented itself.

Despite billionaire Tom Steyer's populist positioning, Bonta could boast the most progressive track record in the field. He is well known in Sacramento, having spent nearly a decade in the Legislature after being elected to the Assembly representing an Alameda-based district in 2012. That might give him an edge over former Orange County Rep. Katie Porter, who has been near the top of the polls but whom Sacramento insiders are hesitant to embrace because she is not one of them. Bonta has been a longtime ally of organized labor -- the California Labor Federation gave Bonta a 100% labor voting record in his last year in the Legislature.

Bonta has to make his final decision on running for governor -- and abandoning his plans to run for reelection -- soon, as the governor's race will accelerate and he already has a lot of work to do to let voters know what office he is pursuing. If he leaves the AG job, there is already a line forming of candidates readying to run, including Assembly Member Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino (Los Angeles County), and state Sen. Dave Cortese, D-San Jose. San Francisco District Attorney Brooke Jenkins of San Francisco, Los Angeles District Attorney Nathan Hochman of Los Angeles and San Francisco City Attorney David Chiu could also be eyeing the job should it become open.

But we're getting way ahead of ourselves here. There would be some major obstacles to Bonta's candidacy. Unlike Harris, whom he backed until she decided not to run for governor, his entry wouldn't clear the field. And unlike his second choice, Sen. Alex Padilla (who also declined to run), he wouldn't likely jump to near the top of the polls. If Bonta got in, he likely would supplant -- or match -- Rep. Eric Swalwell, who holds a slight lead in the way-too-early polls. Bontadoesn't have an overwhelming amount of statewide name recognition. He'd be another strong Democrat in the battle royale with many of the same positions as the other candidates.

And he'd be carrying baggage. As Politico pointed out, he's given multiple answers to why he spent nearly $500,000 in campaign funds on legal services amid a federal bribery investigation expanding from the federal indictment of former Oakland Mayor Sheng Thao. Bonta has a well-documented history -- with tons of bro-y social media photos -- with David and Andy Duong, father-son executives of a waste management company who, along with Thao and her partner Andre Jones, were indicted in January on federal charges of bribery. All have pleaded not guilty. Bonta has not been accused of any wrongdoing and told the Chronicle, "Some people that you know in politics want to take a photo with you every time they see you."

In November, the East Bay Insiders Substack published a 2024 letter to Bonta alleging that Andy Duong had a compromising video of Bonta for potential use as blackmail. The letter was written by Mario Juarez, an East Bay businessman and political operative who is widely believed to be a key witness in the ongoing federal case. Juarez has not been charged, and is referenced in court documents only as a co-conspirator.

Opposing campaigns would make sure that voters hear about those alleged ties. And while Bonta may be well supported by independent committees funded by labor, he won't be able to match the wallet of Steyer, a billionaire former hedge fund manager and Democratic donor and philanthropist.

So why run? Bonta is only 53. He's got a lot of time to run for higher office. For now, keep doing your day job well.

That's the best résumé builder possible. It's a path few electeds choose.

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